

THE MEDICINAL TREK

10 Days · Paro · Jomolhari · Thimphu

A journey through Bhutan's healing landscape — the Jomolhari Trek walked not as a mountain challenge but as a passage through one of the world's great living pharmacies. Every day guided by an expert herbalist who names the plants growing along the trail, explains their uses in Bhutanese traditional medicine, and reveals the botanical knowledge that has sustained these valleys for centuries. The trek culminates in the capital with a traditional pulse-reading by a practising physician. This is not merely a mountain trek. It is a pilgrimage through the Land of Medicinal Herbs.

Day 1 | Arrival — Blessing for the Journey

Arrive into the Paro Valley. Afternoon: a blessing ceremony at a centuries-old temple, butter lamps offered for safe passage through the mountains ahead.

Day 2 | The Tiger's Nest — First Plants

Hike to the Tiger's Nest through blue pine and rhododendron forest — 2 to 3 hours up. The first medicinal plants of the journey are introduced along the trail. Evening: meet your expert herbalist, who introduces the philosophy of Bhutanese herbal medicine and the botanical world that awaits at higher elevation.

Day 3 | Into the National Park — Trek Begins

Drive to the trailhead where the road ends and the trek begins. Walk through temperate forest — blue pine, fir, juniper, rhododendron — as your guide introduces the first of the healing plants growing naturally along the route. Camp in the forest at elevation.

Day 4 | Ascent to the Base of the Sacred Peak

Climb through alpine meadows as the diversity of medicinal plants intensifies. Pass through an ancient highland settlement where families have preserved their knowledge of these plants for generations. Arrive at the base camp beneath the sacred snow peak — 4,100 metres, the sky a different colour entirely.

Day 5 | The Alpine Pharmacy — Acclimatisation Day

A rest day woven into exploration. Guided walks to a glacial lake and surrounding ridges, where high-altitude medicinal and aromatic plants grow in conditions found nowhere at lower elevation. Your guide reveals the alpine pharmacy: rare orchids, blue Himalayan poppies, primulas, cordyceps, aromatic scree-adapted herbs. The seasonal harvesting calendar explained in full.

Day 6 | Descent from the Peak

Begin the descent from base camp — a final exploration of the hardy alpine herbs that survive the fiercer conditions at this altitude before the path leads back down into the temperate forest below.

Day 7 | Return to the Valley

Final trekking day — descending through the rhododendron and pine forest where the journey began. The plants are recognised now, not as curiosities but as medicines. Arrive at the trailhead by midday and drive back to Paro. Evening: a traditional hot herbal bath, deeply restorative after days at altitude.

Day 8 | The Pulse Reading

Transfer to the capital. Morning: a traditional pulse-reading with a practising Bhutanese physician — an ancient diagnostic practice that reads the constitution of the body through the pulse and offers personalised guidance rooted in classical medical texts. Afternoon: optional visits to a traditional arts school, a craft bazaar, or the national traditional medicine hospital.

Day 9 | The Capital at Leisure

A free day in the capital — cafés, craft markets, or simply rest after the mountains.

Day 10 | Departure

After breakfast, transfer to the airport for your onward journey.